
BEFORE YOU PLAN

1. Decide between time and money (wedding planner vs. doing it yourself)

Honestly, that's the decision you face. You can save your time and hire someone to do most of the legwork for you, or you can do it yourself and avoid paying a planner's fees. Your time, your money, your choice. I did it myself, and wouldn't have it any other way. Then again, I also like to be in control. Go figure.

2. Decide what's important

Where do you want to spend your money? On what? What have you dreamed about having in your wedding for so long that to forgo it would make the very event something other than a wedding? For me, these were my dress, my pictures, and my flowers.

3. Decide what's not important

There's a lot of hype surrounding weddings. One trip to a wedding convention, or even a perusal through a wedding magazine will give you multiple introductions to the wedding industry, also known as

"those people who try to make you want stuff for your wedding so bad you'll pay outrageous prices for it." Beat them at their game by deciding what you won't spend money on. Mine? Cake, church decorations, and the reception.

4. Prioritize what's important

Even among the important things (or if everything's important), impose some sort of hierarchy. What is necessary? What would be wonderful but isn't necessary? What can go, if push comes to shove? My list: dress, pictures, flowers, cake, reception, church decorations.

5. Purchase a "bargain" book (but only one)

These really are helpful, particularly if you shop wisely and select one that has good information for your area and on the topics that are most important to you. I lost my planning book somewhere in the process (after its main period of usefulness and before I moved), so I can't tell you what it was. Do only buy one, though; they tend to be repetitive, and could create a substantial hole in your budget. Better yet, borrow one from a friend (or get her to give it to you—like she needs it anymore).